



Pentagon told to plan for major budget cuts

8% slashes each of next 5 years; savings could go toward Trump priorities

BY DAN LAMOTHE, ALEX HORTON AND HANNAH NATANSON

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth has ordered senior leaders at the Pentagon and throughout the U.S. military to develop plans for cutting 8 percent from the defense budget in each of the next five years, according to a memo obtained by The Washington Post and officials familiar with the matter — a striking proposal certain to face internal resistance and strident bipartisan opposition in Congress.

Hegseth ordered the proposed cuts to be drawn up by Monday, according to the memo, which is dated Tuesday and includes a list of 17 categories that the Trump administration wants exempted. Among them: operations at the southern U.S. border, modernization of nuclear weapons and missile defense, and acquisition of submarines, one-way attack drones and other munitions.

Robert G. Salesses, a senior Pentagon official, said in a statement that the money saved could be “realigned” to pay for new priorities in the Trump administration, including the “Iron Dome for America,” President Donald Trump’s catchphrase for an expansive missile defense system. That sum could amount to \$50 billion in next year’s budget, he said.

The Pentagon budget for 2025 is about \$850 billion, with broad consensus on Capitol Hill that extensive spending is necessary

SEE PENTAGON ON A6

Alleged threats: D.C.’s top prosecutor probes Democrats. **B1**

Former agents booted by FBI provide Patel a support circle

BY MARK BERMAN, JEREMY ROEBUCK, PERRY STEIN AND CLARA ENCE MORSE

Kash Patel, a fierce critic of the FBI, is on the verge of being confirmed as the bureau’s next director, with a full Senate vote expected Thursday.

If approved, he would take over the agency amid turmoil unlike anything in its 116-year history, while facing allegations that he played a role in purges of at least eight top officials while his nomination was pending.

Some of those forced out had been vilified for years by a group of former agents who have previously been accused of misconduct and suspended, a Washington Post examination has found.

The ex-agents, who deny wrongdoing, have forged bonds with Patel, in some cases accepting financial help from his non-profit foundation, and have been in contact with him since his nomination, one member of the group said in an interview. They testified on Capitol Hill about the need to clean house at the FBI, including at a hearing organized by Rep. Jim Jordan (R-Ohio) in 2023.

Jordan’s senior staff at the

SEE FBI ON A5

Claim of ‘disinformation’ in war of words

President Donald Trump attacked Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky on social media Wednesday, calling him a “dictator” and falsely describing his poll numbers. The Kremlin has made similar statements.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky
To Ukrainian TV early Wednesday

“We have evidence that these figures are being discussed between America and Russia. That is, President Trump ... unfortunately lives in this disinformation space.”

President Donald Trump
From a 10:47 a.m. post on Truth Social

“Think of it, a modestly successful comedian, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, talked the United States of America into spending \$350 Billion Dollars, to go into a War that couldn’t be won, that never had to start, but a War that he, without the U.S. and “TRUMP,” will never be able to settle ... On top of this, Zelenskyy admits that half of the money we sent him is “MISSING.” He refuses to have Elections, is very low in Ukrainian Polls, and the only thing he was good at was playing Biden “like a fiddle.” A Dictator without Elections, Zelenskyy better move fast or he is not going to have a Country left..... ”

Zelensky, responding to Trump’s post
At a Wednesday news conference

“If anyone wants to replace me right now, then it just isn’t going to happen. I wish Trump’s team had more truth. Because none of this is having a positive effect on Ukraine.”

Allies fear U.S. may realign its Russia policy

TRUMP APPEARS TO MOVE CLOSER TO PUTIN

President taunts Zelensky, leaving Europe dismayed

BY KAREN DEYOUNG AND MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

President Donald Trump and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky traded insults Wednesday, with Zelensky accusing Trump of spouting lies about him and the war with Russia and Trump calling Zelensky a “dictator” who started the war and has been ripping off the United States to pay for it.

Beneath the war of words is rising concern here and in Europe that what has seemed a head-spinning move away from decades of U.S. policy toward Russia, and three years of stalwart support for Ukraine, may lead to the most significant geopolitical realignment since World War II. While Trump was sympathetic toward Russian President Vladimir Putin during his first term, he now appears to be upending generations of U.S. caution toward the Kremlin that has spanned both Republican and Democratic administrations.

Zelensky’s Wednesday push-back seemed to boost his popularity at home. But this week’s escalating exchange led some of the



Trump

Zelensky

United States’ closest European allies, who have expressed subdued concern over Trump’s move toward Moscow, to go public with remarks ranging from dismay to outrage.

“We do not understand the American logic very well,” French government spokeswoman Sophie Primas said, calling Trump’s comments “diverse, varied and often incomprehensible.” German Chancellor Olaf Scholz said Trump’s remarks were “wrong and dangerous,” while his foreign minister, Annalena Baerbock, called on Trump to “look at the real world instead of just tweeting.”

British Prime Minister Keir

SEE TRUMP ON A4

Zelensky support: “Dictator” talk angers and unites Ukrainians. **A11**

After committing money, GOP senators plead for it to be spent

BY LIZ GOODWIN

Republican senators find themselves in an unusual position these days: begging Trump officials to release funds they themselves appropriated.

Senators have in recent days made the case to Cabinet secretaries and other Trump officials to let money flow back into their states. They are trying to finagle exceptions to President Donald Trump’s sweeping executive orders or cuts made by billionaire Elon Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service

While backing cuts, they press Cabinet to preserve favored programs

that freeze hundreds of billions of dollars, including money for farmers and infrastructure projects. That push comes as the administration has also sought to fire a wide swath of federal employees — some of whom live in red states.

Even as many Republicans praise the ultimate goal of streamlining the federal government, some GOP senators spanning the ideological spectrum from Katie Boyd Britt (Alabama) to Lisa Murkowski (Alaska) have lobbied the Trump administration to reconsider its cuts or pauses to federal grants that support biomedical research and labs, or for programs supporting Native American tribes.

It’s a humbling turn of events for a body that has traditionally prized its power of the purse. The

aggressive move to cut spending unilaterally “negates Congress’s hard-won power over appropriations,” said Jessica Riedl, a budget expert with the conservative Manhattan Institute think tank, who predicted lawmakers were “afraid” to more forcefully grab back their appropriations power given Trump’s popularity with the GOP base.

“Eventually Congress is going to have to take back its power of the purse rather than nicely asking the administration for favors,” she said.

But Sen. Tommy Tuberville (R-Alabama), a close Trump ally who supports the cuts, said last week that begging for funds may be the new normal, suggesting that lawmakers could lobby Musk to save spending they’ve allocated for their states as he slashes and cancels contracts at agencies.

“If we have to lobby for, ‘Hey wait a minute, what about the bridge in Birmingham?’ or, ‘There’s a bridge in Mobile’ or whatever, I think that could be very possible,” Tuberville told

SEE FUNDS ON A7

After collision, the hardest day for first responders

This article is by Joe Heim, Emma Uber, Jenny Gathright, Paul Duggan and Peter Hermann

As American Eagle Flight 5342 headed from Wichita to Reagan National Airport on Jan. 29, Asra Hussain texted her husband, Hamaad Raza.

“We’re landing in 20,” the 26-year-old wrote at 8:17 p.m.

Raza left their apartment in the District to pick her up.

At Fire Station 204 in Alexandria, 2½ miles from the airport, the night had been quiet. Crew members on duty washed dishes and swept the kitchen after a pot roast dinner. The firehouse doors were locked and most lights turned off. Capt. Nathan Krause, 43, finished up paperwork and got ready to turn in for the night.

As the plane neared the airport, the pilots were asked by an air traffic controller if they would land on Runway 33, a maneuver that requires the plane to head eastward, then make a swooping turn low across the Potomac River. It was a familiar request, and the pilots adjusted the approach of the plane carrying 64 people.

SEE CRASH ON A18



JOHN MCDONNELL FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Alexandria Fire Capt. Nathan Krause led a water rescue team that responded to the Jan. 29 crash. “We heard that transmission, and that was all we needed to hear,” he said. “It was just get up and go.”

Worker firings quickly lead to disruptions at national parks

BY MAXINE JOSELOW AND ANDREA SACHS

At California’s Yosemite National Park, the Trump administration fired the only locksmith on staff Friday. He was the sole employee with the keys and the institutional knowledge needed to rescue visitors from locked restrooms.

The wait to enter Arizona’s Grand Canyon National Park this past weekend was twice as long as usual after the administration let go four employees who worked at the south entrance, which roughly 90 percent of the park’s nearly 5 million annual visitors pass through.

And at Gettysburg National Military Park in Pennsylvania, last week’s widespread layoffs gutted the team that managed reservations for renting historic farmhouses. Visitors received notifications that their reservations

SEE PARKS ON A5

IN THE NEWS

Eric Adams case The Justice Department defended its move to drop charges against New York’s mayor, and both sides rejected any assertion that there’s a quid pro quo. **A2**

Greater scrutiny overseas Lawmakers in Maryland are aiming to regulate tourism after two residents died in a Hajj pilgrimage. **B1**

THE NATION
A Trump order says there are “two sexes,” but researchers say it’s not so simple. **A3**
The USDA is working to reverse the accidental firings of bird flu response workers. **A6**

THE WORLD
Pacific island nations were awarded millions to help adapt to dwindling stocks of tuna. **A9**
Medical evacuations from Gaza have slowed down amid fears about the ability to return. **A10**

THE ECONOMY
Lori Chavez-DeRemer testified at a hearing on her selection as labor secretary, highlighting GOP tensions over labor unions. **A13**
The White House moved to revoke federal approval for New York City’s congestion pricing toll program. **A14**

THE REGION
Lawmakers voted to tighten Virginia’s notoriously loose campaign-finance laws by banning the personal use of campaign funds. **B1**
A man who wielded a knife after crashing into a D.C. police car and attempted a carjacking was killed by police. **B1**

STYLE
E Street Cinema, a bastion for independent and international films in downtown Washington, will be closing. **C1**
LOCAL LIVING
Eight modern rules for being a better houseguest. Top of the list: Yes, you still need to bring a host gift.

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